

Courtright**Collective**

DECIDE IT ONCE

THE LOGO + BRAND STARTER

The Brand Basics *Worksheet*

Fourteen questions and one afternoon. Come out the other side with a name, a mark, a palette, two fonts, and a voice you can actually hold to.

14 QUESTIONS

ONE AFTERNOON

NO DESIGNER

COURTRIGHTCO.COM

BUILT IN NASHVILLE

The Brand Basics Worksheet

Before you start

A brand is not a logo. A brand is the set of decisions you stop re-making.

Right now, every time you post something, print something, or build a page, you are re-deciding what color to use, what font looks right, and how formal to sound. That is exhausting, it is slow, and it is why your stuff does not look like it came from the same place.

Answer the fourteen questions below and you never have to decide any of it again. Then open [brand-board-builder.html](#) and turn the answers into a one-page board you can print and hand to anybody.

This will take an afternoon. Do it in one sitting if you can. Momentum matters more than perfection here, and version one of anything can be fixed in six months when you know more.

Part 1: Who you are (questions 1 to 5)

1. What do you actually do?

One sentence, no adjectives. If it needs an "and," you have two businesses and you should pick one for now.

We [verb] [thing] for [who] .

Your answer:

2. Who is it for, specifically?

"Everyone" makes every decision downstream impossible. Get to a person you could describe to a stranger.

- Age range, roughly:
- What they do:
- Where they are:
- What they were doing five minutes before they needed you:
- What they are afraid of getting wrong:

3. What do people actually come to you for?

Not what you wish. What they say when they call.

▪ 4. What is genuinely different about you?

The honest answer, not the marketing answer. "We answer the phone" is a real differentiator in a lot of industries. So is "we are the only one open Sundays."

▪ 5. Who are your three closest competitors, and what do they look like?

Go look at their sites right now. Write down the pattern.

COMPETITOR	COLORS THEY USE	HOW THEY SOUND

The pattern in your industry is: _____

You are going to: ☐ fit the pattern (safe, faster trust) ☐ break it deliberately (memorable, riskier)

Both are legitimate. Choosing on purpose is the point. Every plumber has a blue and red truck, which means the green truck gets remembered, and also means somebody has to think twice about whether it is a plumber.

Part 2: The name and the mark (questions 6 to 8)

▪ 6. Your name, and how it gets written

- Full legal name:
- How it appears in your logo:
- Short version, for tight spaces:
- Do you use "the"? Circle one: yes / no. Then never change it again

▪ 7. Your monogram

For a one-person or small business, initials in a colored block are a completely legitimate logo. They work at every size, they cost nothing, they never look dated, and they will not be mistaken for a stock icon of a leaf.

- Monogram (1 to 3 characters): _____
- Shape: ☐ rounded square ☐ circle ☐ hard square

Do not use a generic icon of a house, a leaf, a swoosh, a gear, or a lightbulb. Every business in your category has already used it and yours will look like theirs.

▪ 8. The name test

Before you commit, run all six:

- [] Say it out loud on a phone call. Does it need spelling?
- [] **.com** available, or an acceptable variant
- [] The handle is free on the one social platform you will actually use

- [] Search it. Are you competing with a bigger business for your own name?
 - [] No accidental other meaning. Say the initials out loud too
 - [] You can imagine saying it for ten years without cringing
-

Part 3: Color (questions 9 to 11)

9. Pick your primary

This is your one accent. Buttons, links, the thing you want clicked.

How to pick, if you are stuck:

- Start from something real: your building, your product, the thing you make, a photo you love
- Or pick the opposite of your industry's default and see how it feels
- Avoid pure red (alarming), pure black as an accent (it is your ink, not your accent), and neon anything (it fails contrast and it dates)

Your primary: # _____

10. Pick a secondary and a highlight

- **Secondary:** a deeper or darker relative of your primary. Use it for gradients, hovers, and depth
- **Highlight:** a contrasting warm or bright note. Badges, small accents, under 10 percent of any layout

Picking a pair that works: stay within about 60 degrees of each other on the color wheel, or go fully opposite and commit. Anything between those two looks like an accident. The safest move of all is one color plus a lighter, warmer version of itself.

Your secondary: # _____ **Your highlight:** # _____

11. Pick your ink and your background

- **Ink:** your darkest color, for all body text. Not pure black. A very dark version of your primary reads warmer and more intentional
- **Background:** your lightest. Not pure white. A slightly warm off-white is easier to read for long stretches and instantly looks more considered

Your ink: # _____ **Your background:** # _____

Then check contrast. The brand board builder does this for you and grades every color. Anything marked "Not for text" can be a background or a shape, but must never carry small type. This is the single most common mistake in small business branding, and it is the one that quietly makes people give up on your website.

Part 4: Type (question 12)

12. Pick two fonts. Two. Not three.

- **Headings:** carries the personality

- **Body:** carries the reading

Pairing rules that always work:

- Serif headings plus sans-serif body. The reliable, classic choice
- Sans headings plus serif body. Modern, works well for anything editorial
- One font at two weights. Boring on paper, looks expensive in practice

Use fonts that are already on every device unless you have a real reason not to. Nothing to download, nothing to license, nothing that fails to load and falls back to Times New Roman on somebody's work laptop.

Your headings: **Your body:**

The read-aloud test: set a real paragraph in your body font and read it. If it feels like a hospital form or a wedding invitation and you are neither, change it now, while changing it is free.

Part 5: Voice (questions 13 to 14)

▪ 13. We sound like

Three adjectives, then one sentence that shows it.

Adjectives: , ,

In a sentence:

▪ 14. We never sound like

This one does more work than the last one. Naming what you are not is how you catch yourself drifting.

Then write these three lines in your voice. They are the ones you will reuse forever, so getting them right here saves you a hundred small decisions later.

- **The greeting** (how you answer the phone or open an email):
- **The bad news line** (how you say "no" or "it will be late"):
- **The close** (how you sign off):

Part 6: Build the board

Open [brand-board-builder.html](#) in any browser. Type in everything above. You get a live one-page brand board with:

- Your logo lockup
- Your palette, with every color graded for readability against your background
- A type specimen showing headings, body, and small print
- Buttons, badges, and links in your colors
- Your voice, both sides

- Usage rules, including automatic warnings about any color that fails contrast

Print it, save it as a PDF, or download it as a self-contained HTML file. Then:

1. Put it where you will find it. Not buried in a folder
2. Send it to anybody who makes anything for you
3. Do not change it for six months, even when you get bored of it

That last one matters more than any other line in this worksheet. You will get sick of your brand long before your customers even notice it exists. Consistency is what makes a small business look established, and the only way to be consistent is to stop fiddling.

What to do next, in order

1. **Update your profile pictures** everywhere. Same mark, same crop, all platforms
 2. **Update your email signature.** The Email Signature Pack does this in five minutes
 3. **Update your website colors** to your palette. Even if the site is not great, consistent beats clever
 4. **Print something.** Cards, a sign, a sticker. Seeing it in the physical world tells you fast whether it works
 5. **Wait six months before you change anything**
-

The honest caveat

This gets you a solid, consistent, professional-looking brand you can run for years. It does not get you a custom illustrated identity from a designer who spent three weeks on your story, and it is not pretending to.

For most small businesses, consistent beats custom, and having decided beats having deliberated. When you are big enough that a real identity project pays for itself, do that. Until then, this is the version that gets used.

courtrightco.com